

Future Insights: The FoodTech Report 2021

In the first of a series of industry reports, we've partnered with Huckletree to demystify the foodtech space and explore the companies transforming what we eat and how we eat it.

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2021

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Details on the biggest players in the space, and how they're scaling operations

Which areas of the UK are producing the most high-growth foodtechs

Top investors in the space and how much capital they're deploying

Emerging trends, from precision agriculture to urban farming

The rise of veganism and the companies fuelling its growth

A breakdown of the biggest players in on-demand groceries

Here's a sneak-peak inside

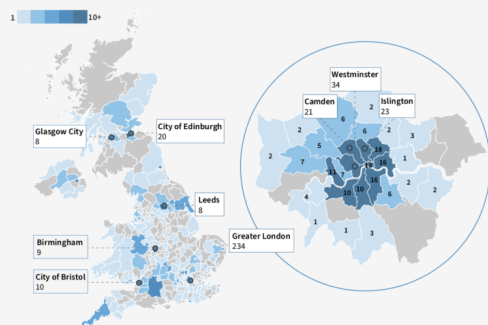
FoodTech map of the UK

There are innovative FoodTech companies popping up all over the UK to reshape the food industry with technology. Home to 234 active high-growth FoodTech startups, London has the highest density of companies among all regions in the country — it is the natural geographical leader for this emerging industry.

Of the top 12 UK local authorities with the most FoodTech businesses, 10 are located in the capital, with the leaders being Westminster, Islington and Camden. Some of the fastest-growing London FoodTech businesses include online supermarket Farmdrop for consumers to order produce directly from farmers, as well as FinTech startup Velocity, which uses Artificial Intelligence for recommendations and bookings for restaurants and other venues.

The local authority outside London with the most high-growth FoodTech companies is Edinburgh, where 20 are currently headquartered. One such business is QikServe, offering convenience in orders and payment for restaurant patrons through a self-service app, which has raised £11.8m of investment.

Number of high-growth FoodTech companies in the UK by local authority area (2021)



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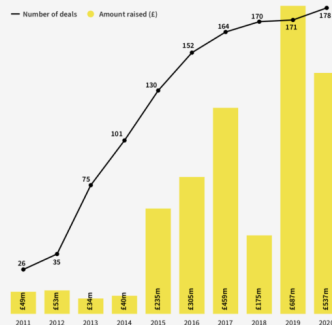
Investment trends

The annual number of equity investments into UK FoodTech companies has climbed steadily since 2011. The decade saw a total of 1,202 deals worth £2.6b. The top year for investment by value was 2019 which saw an enormous £687m worth of fundraising.

The company that secured the most equity investment between 2011 and 2020 by far was Deliveroo, raising £1.1b in this period and then a further £1.32m in January 2021. The unicorn food delivery company then underwent an IPO in March. The next five companies that raised the most between 2011 and 2020 — Karma Kitchen, Goobis, HungryPanda, Just Eat and Rekkis — secured a total of £602m between them.

For 526 of the deals made over the decade, it was the first time the company making the deal secured equity fundraising. With this number being almost half the total of the 1,202 deals, the FoodTech business ecosystem is clearly in its early stages. As more investors pay attention to the intersection of food and technology, the number of deals will likely continue to rise, particularly as investors follow their earlier investments.

Equity investment into UK FoodTech companies (2011–2020)



1,202
rounds of equity investment
2011–2020

£2.6b
total equity investment raised
2011–2020

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Freya performs data analysis and visualisation in the Research and Consultancy team. She has worked on projects for Barclays, EY and JP Morgan. She holds a BA in History (International) from the University of Leeds, which included a year at Fudan University in Shanghai, and is currently learning Python for data science.

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